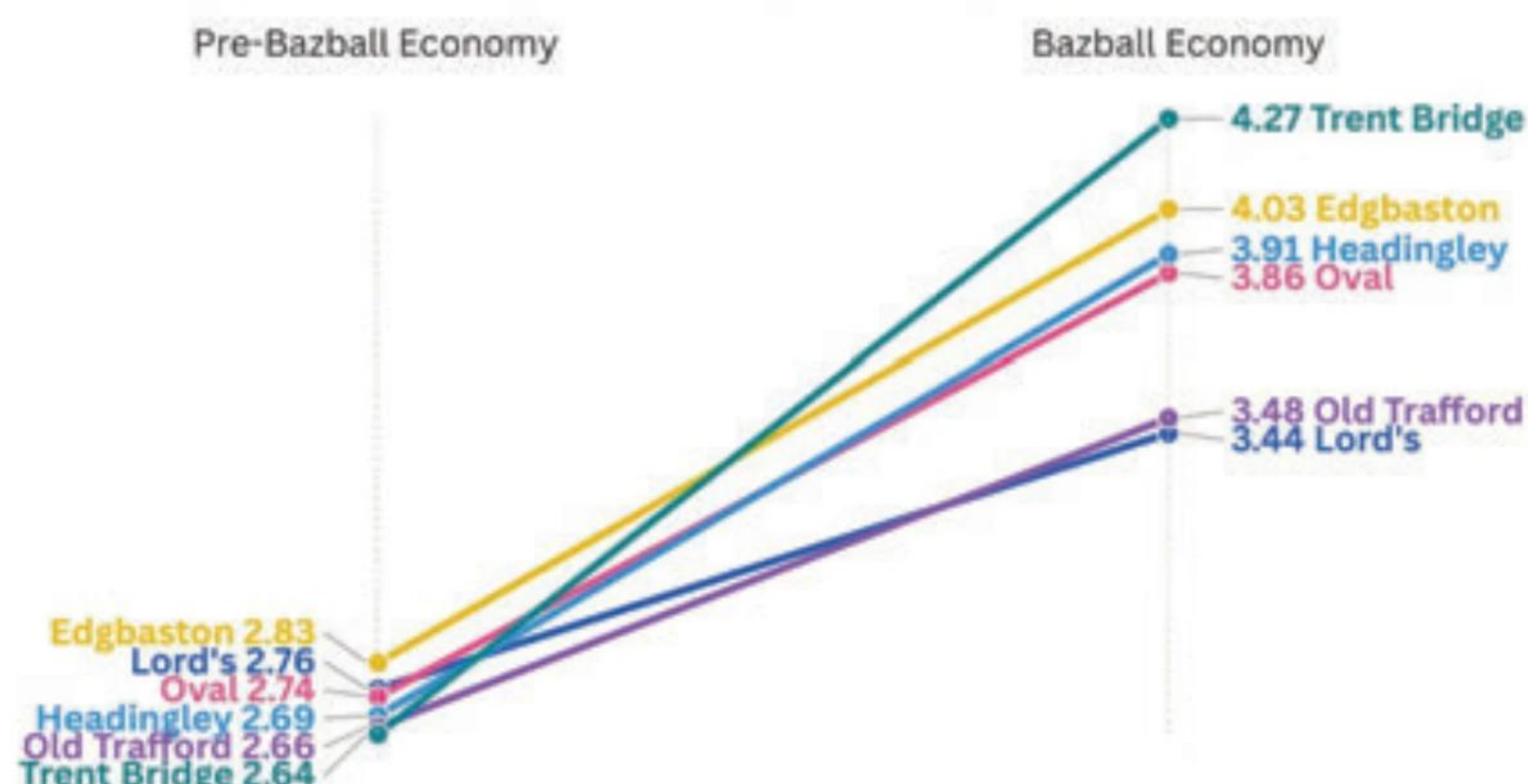
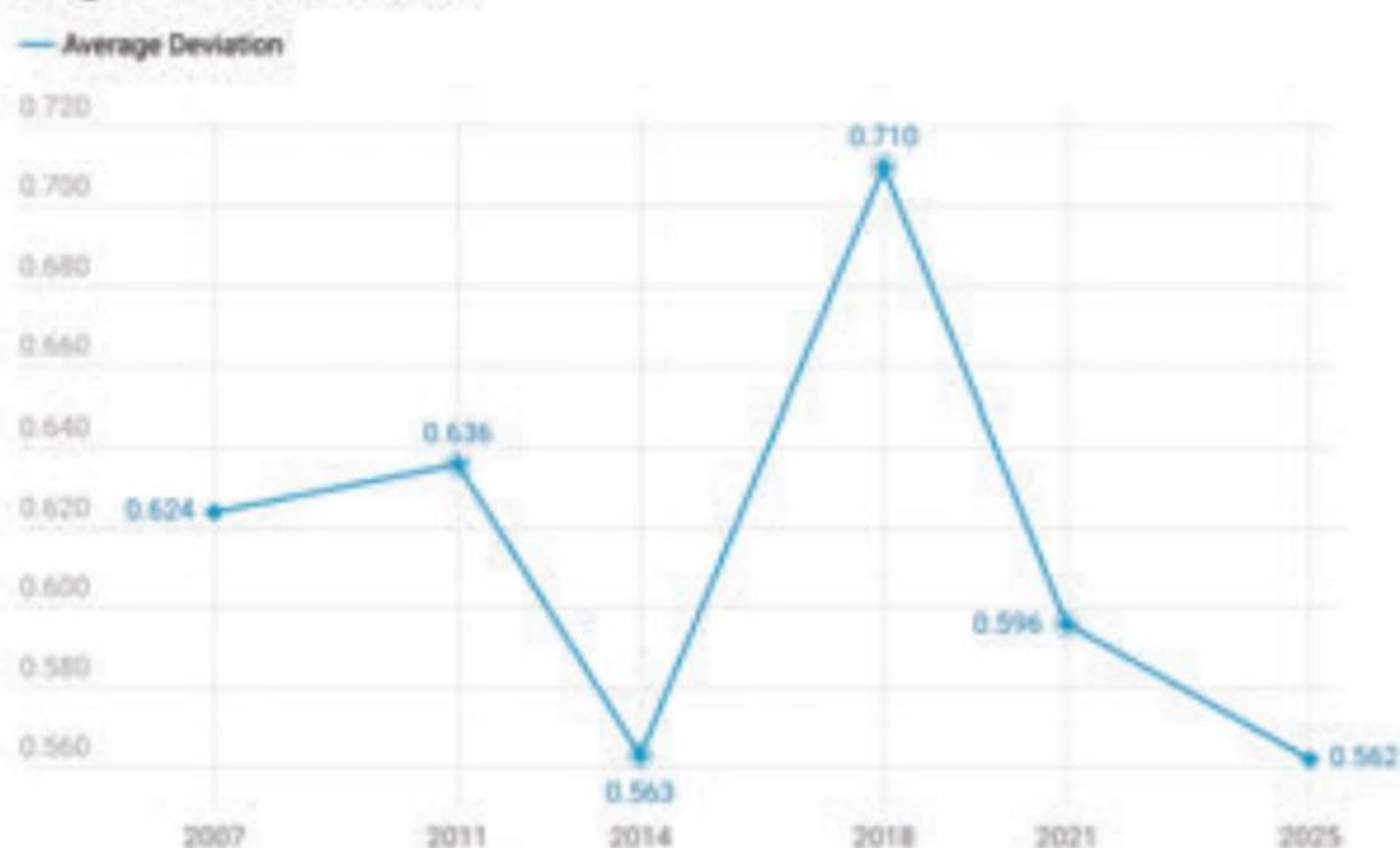


Test bowling economy in England grounds



Average deviation for pacers in India's away Test series in England since 2007



which have become integral to England's home Test strategy.

Since Brendon McCullum's appointment as head coach in 2022, England has played at six home venues — Lord's, Headingley, The Oval, Old Trafford, Trent Bridge and Edgbaston.

Four of these have undergone a marked transformation. Once offering an even contest between bat and ball, they have become heavily tilted towards batting.

This aligns with McCullum's philosophy of hyper-aggressive batting, reflected in the rising scoring rates at every English Test ground.

Trent Bridge has experienced the

most dramatic shift. Before the advent of 'Bazball', bowlers there averaged 31.25 while conceding 2.64 runs per over. Since then, the average has ballooned to 43.01, with the run rate soaring to 4.27.

Ironically, Trent Bridge was the only major ground not to host a match during the Anderson-Tendulkar Trophy.

Nevertheless, the series was played on lifeless surfaces, unlike anything Indian batters have encountered in England in recent memory.

According to Cricviz, the average deviation for pace bowlers was just 0.562 degrees — the lowest for a Test

series involving India in England since ball-tracking data began in 2005.

The average swing for pacers was 0.899 degrees, the sixth-lowest for any Test series in England of at least three matches.

Notably, three of the six lowest figures in that list have come during the Bazball era.

By prioritising maximum batting returns, England has enjoyed strong results at home under McCullum and Ben Stokes, not having lost a home series during this period, with 17 wins and only six defeats.

However, the tactic has not yielded series victories in the two marquee contests it has hosted in the last three years — the 2023 Ashes and the Anderson-Tendulkar Trophy.

While the batting-friendly conditions ensured relentless entertainment, they took a visible toll on the bowlers.

By the time the series reached The Oval, both teams were without their frontline pace spearheads — Jofra Archer and Jasprit Bumrah were rested for workload management, while Stokes was sidelined with an injury sustained from long, taxing spells earlier in the series.

Whether England's policy of 'dead-pitching' opponents is sustainable remains an open question.